> fuelling, arming, targeting, and firing an SS-4 [R-12] are all processes that require coordinated action by a large number of skilled people. Even if warheads were present for the missiles in Cuba, if the crews manning the sites had not panicked and run for cover, if they had not waited for orders from superiors, and if they had escaped death or bodily injury in the attack (all major assumptions), it would still have been virtually impossible to accomplish this extraordinarily complex coordinated activity safely and effectively while American high-explosive and incendiary bombs [napalm] were falling in the area.[63]

It seems extremely unlikely that General Pliyev (or any of his subordinate commanders) would have been able to 'launch on warning' or 'launch under attack' (even if nuclear warheads were available). Blight and Welch explain that at the meeting on 21 October, General Sweeney failed to communicate to President Kennedy the unlikelihood of any 'launch under attack'. However, on 26 October John McCone told the President that further analysis in CIA had revised their assessment of the likely effectiveness of an attack. McCone reported that military analysts seconded to the agency believed, 'there's a *higher* probability of immobilizing these missiles, *all of them*, with a strike' than previously thought.[64]

Would the Soviets have fired their surviving missiles? The US and UK intelligence communities thought not. On 16 October Robert McNamara and Dean Rusk took different sides. The Secretary of State was convinced that the Soviets would not fire missiles from Cuba unless they were going to wage general nuclear war. Assuming they did not intend to wage general nuclear war, they would not fire any surviving missiles. The Secretary of Defense was more exercised about the reliability of Soviet command and control and the possibility of what he later termed some 'damn Soviet second lieutenant' firing a missile at a US city. 'We don't know what kinds of communications the Soviets have with those sites. We don't know what kinds of control they have over the warheads,' he warned.[65] The command and control of nuclear weapons lies at the heart of debates about the risk of inadvertent nuclear war during the Cold War (and beyond). Procedures for